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Fed up with brands that use corn syrup and skim milk, this mother developed her own 'clean' baby formula



Lauren Forristal — 7:30 AM PDT · July 29, 2025

When Esther Hallam welcomed her daughter, Nara, into the world, she faced the challenge of searching for trustworthy brands that offered high-quality organic infant formula in the U.S.

Despite being available for nearly 160 years, the quality of infant formula options in the U.S. is still lacking, she believes. Many manufacturers opt for skim milk to cut costs, which allows them to add oils to meet nutritional requirements. Several formulas contain palm oil, soy, and corn syrup, which aren't recommended for infants due to their potential health risks.

For instance, [research](#) has linked corn syrup to an increased risk of obesity, while palm oil has been shown to [decrease calcium and fat absorption](#).

"I became fixated by the fact that there wasn't a good, organic infant formula that I trusted, that I wanted to feed my daughter in the United States, which is a first-world country," Hallam told TechCrunch.

For the past seven years, Hallam has been developing her own organic, whole-milk infant formula from scratch, with the help of scientists and pediatric nutritionists.

Today marks the official launch of [Nara Organics](#), which meets both European and U.S. safety standards, and is FDA-registered and USDA-

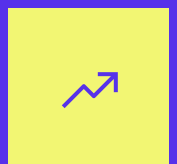
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certified. Most importantly, the formula is free from palm oil, soy, corn syrup, maltodextrin, and genetically modified organisms (GMOs), providing a clean option for conscientious parents looking to nourish their babies with the best possible ingredients.

Nara Organics claims to have the highest percentage of milk fat of any formula sold in the U.S. It also has the lowest percentage of plant-based oils, as the use of whole milk means that less oil is needed to achieve the correct fat content. The ingredient list on the package includes an “organic vegetable oil blend” made up of organic sunflower, coconut, and rapeseed oils, which provide essential fatty acids that support healthy development.

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IMAGE CREDITS: NARA ORGANICS

While there are several brands with organic formulas, such as Bobbie and ByHeart, these products are manufactured in the U.S.

In contrast, Nara Organics chose not to produce its formula in American facilities, potentially due to previous issues with *Cronobacter* contamination, a germ that can survive in dry foods. In recent years, there have been [several](#) recalls of [baby formula](#) linked to outbreaks of *Cronobacter*.

This is why the company prefers to manufacture its formula in Germany, which just so happens to be the birthplace of powdered infant formula.

Chief marketing officer Meika Hollender explained to TechCrunch that the company's manufacturing partner utilizes technology "that doesn't exist anywhere else in the world."

"A critical piece of infant formula, in terms of its shelf life, is how much oxygen gets into the can while you're sealing it. So if you go to facilities in the U.S., they're open. When you're filling, canning, and sealing the can, they're just sort of out in the open air of the facility. And at our facility, the cans actually go into this chamber that has no oxygen in them," Hollender said.

Nara has secured a total of \$32 million from AlleyCorp, BBG Ventures, Corazon Ventures, Gingerbread Capital, and Torch Capital. Additionally, the company has attracted attention from high-profile celebrity investors, including tennis superstar Serena Williams, “Jane the Virgin” actress Gina Rodriguez, and the creators of “Nobody Wants This,” [Erin and Sara Foster](#), among others.

Nicky Hilton, fashion designer and philanthropist, is also an investor and advisor.

“I breastfed all of my three children, but they also all had formula,” Hilton told us. “Every baby and parent is different, and not all mothers are able to breastfeed due to medical, physical, or personal reasons. I think there’s so much judgment and unnecessary pressure about breastfeeding... It’s really exciting to be a part of an innovative brand that is disrupting the baby formula market.”

With this support, Nara Organics could position itself as a key player in the organic formula market, which was valued at approximately [\\$20.7 billion](#) in 2023 and is expected to reach \$37 billion by 2032.



IMAGE CREDITS: NARA ORGANICS

The formula is now available for purchase on the company’s website. Customers can choose the

starter bundle for \$36, which includes two cans. Alternatively, they can sign up for a subscription that delivers either four or six cans every four weeks, priced at \$136 or \$243, respectively. Each can makes about 25 four-ounce bottles.

It also can be purchased through the company's free [mobile app](#), which Hallam launched in 2018. The app is designed to assist users in tracking essential aspects of infant care, including monitoring baby feeding times, keeping a log of wet and soiled diapers, and tracking tummy time exercises.

As part of its launch, the company is donating over 1,400 cans of infant formula to the [Good+Foundation](#), a nonprofit organization working to end multi-generational poverty by supplying essential items and services to under-resourced parents and caregivers.

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Lauren Forristal



Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch.

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Meet Bobbie, a baby formula delivery startup promising healthier ingredients

Sarah Buhr — 10:49 AM PDT · May 10, 2019

IMAGE CREDITS:
VLADMIR GODNIK / GETTY IMAGES

Don't like the idea of your baby guzzling down liquid candy all day? It may surprise you to find corn syrup is the main ingredient in most infant formulas in the U.S. That's where [Bobbie](#), a Bay Area-based baby formula delivery startup promising only wholesome ingredients, hopes to fill in.

Just go down the baby food aisle of any supermarket in America and start reading the ingredients and you'll likely find corn syrup, soy bean oil, glucose syrup, maltodextrin and palm oil at the top. Even ["organic" options](#) often add these ingredients.

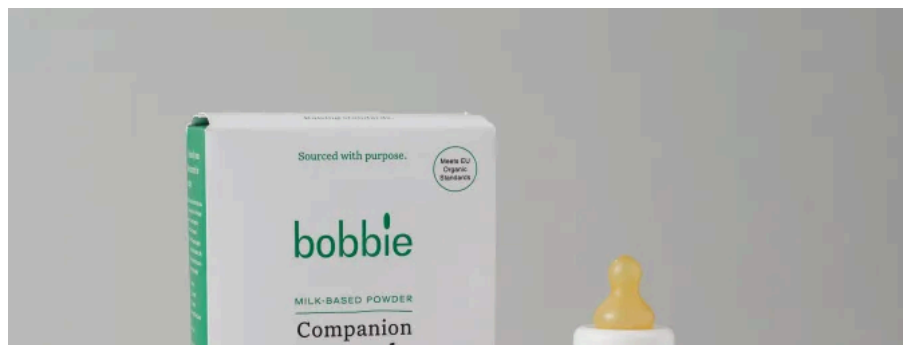
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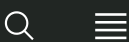
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While it’s high-fructose corn syrup we should be [most concerned](#) with when it comes to diabetes (and some doctors might even recommend adding some sort of syrup to your baby’s diet to combat constipation), corn syrup is not something some parents may want their baby drinking all day.



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grass-fed and corn syrup-free is music to the ears of many parents (me included) who’ve resorted to [ordering bulk from Germany](#) just to avoid feeding our kids Snickers in a bottle.

Yes, it seems crazy to order all the way from Europe when there are so many choices here in the U.S. — and there are some formula manufacturers here

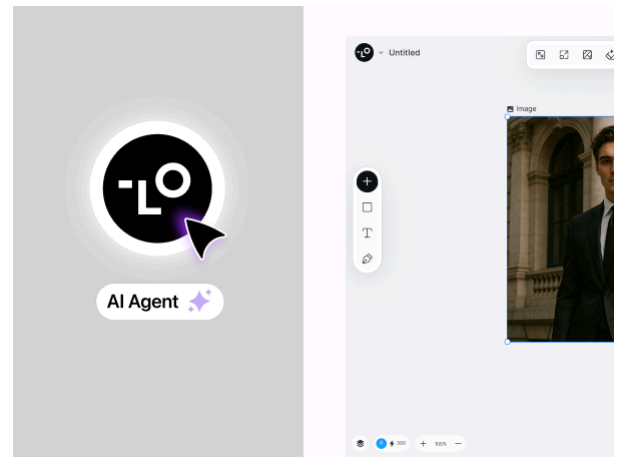
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making an effort to offer better options — but finding something that meets the simple standard of no sugar, corn syrup or processed oils in the baby food is weirdly difficult.

The other nugget Bobbie provides is delivery. Heaven knows every second is precious when you are a new parent. Delivery can be an especially big help in maintaining some semblance of order in those early days. Sure, Amazon delivers many baby things — it even ships the popular, German-based [Hipp](#) brand of formula — but it comes at a premium price and will only ship in bulk.

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You can also get the European brands delivered straight from sites like [Organic Start](#), [Huggable](#) and a number of others easily Googled. But for those wanting something local, slightly less expensive and with presumably less of a carbon footprint than shipping from another continent, Bobbie is here for you (and we're told will be delivered with a soft knock on the door, in case baby is sleeping).

The company was founded by two San Francisco moms and former Airbnb operation leaders Laura Modi and Sarah Hardy. Both found out how hard it was, after returning from maternity leave, to pump each day while keeping up with the demands of the job. However, neither of them liked the formula options they found at the grocery store for their own little broods.

Modi and Hardy thought it was time to give parents a more local choice in healthy formula. The two founded the company in 2018 and pulled in \$2.5 million in funding last year from [Bolt](#), Nextview Ventures, Lakehouse and Precursor while Modi was pregnant, closing the round a week before giving birth to her baby boy.

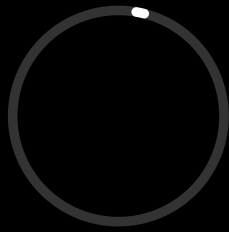
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Bobbie will (appropriately) begin taking orders this Mother’s Day. Unfortunately, Bobbie only delivers to the Bay Area for now. However, those interested can order one 400 g trial box for \$27, which should make about 22 bottles at 6 ounces per bottle, according to a company spokesperson. You can also sign up for the subscription package for \$23 per box.



[Bobbie Baby – Evolving the conversation of parenthood](#) from [Laura Modi](#) on [Vimeo](#).

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